

CALL TRANSCRIPT

Date: March 5, 2025

Parties: Mayor Joy Petro (JP) and Matthew Reardon (MR)

Subject: Follow-up regarding city ID requirements and concerns about Mark Arrington

JP: Hey Matthew, this is Joy. I'm returning your call finally. It took me a minute to get to, you know, just kind of do some investigation here. First off, I want to say thank you for bringing to my attention the fact that in one area we ask for IDs and other areas we don't. I did bring this up to the city manager and said we need consistency throughout the entire department. So it's in so you know, we all can obey the same rules. So he's going to address that right away.

Also, just so you know, as in regards to Mark, I did kind of ask him also to find out what the details there were, what took place as far as his research time or how he got your name and all that good stuff. He did report back to me. And the reason why I'm saying he had to report back to me is because our mayor's role here in this city is we, the city manager actually is the one that I have to go through to discuss any personnel issues. That's just part of the policy and the way it's written up.

So he did investigate and he says that, you know what, he was doing his job. He did what was on time. He did not go in and use any of that crap. I mean, it was just purely, you know, he got on Facebook, I guess, and looked that way.

[Interruption/Connection issue]

JP: Hi, Mayor Petra?

MR: Yes.

JP: I don't know how it even let me even come in. Like, I saw the notification and I clicked on it. And for whatever reason, it let me just... I've never seen that with this phone before. Does your iPhone let you do that?

MR: I don't know. I don't really pay attention.

JP: That's crazy. I thought I was checking the voicemail and I saw it just steadily like leaving the message and I was like, wait, answer? I've never seen this before. Okay. So I literally, I'm sorry, I didn't get around or I wasn't right here by my phone. I had it on charge.

MR: Okay. All right. Can you explain to me what you're saying? Because I haven't had a chance to actually check that voicemail. It was just streaming the line across. I was still rattling on.

JP: So two things. One, first off, I want to say thanks for bringing it to our attention that, you know, in one area you have to show ID, in another area you don't.

MR: Right.

JP: So we're going to make that consistent throughout the city so that there's no doubt there.

MR: Well, yeah, the concerning thing is, you know, like I said, I – The First Amendment, I've had issues with, I think, requiring identification. It's not a requirement of GRAMA. And if it's not a privileged record or a private record, my argument there would be that it shouldn't be required. Where are y'all going on that?

JP: You know, I had the conversation with him yesterday. On Monday.

MR: Okay.

JP: And well, actually last week, after you and I spoke, I did get a hold of him. And then Monday, I did a follow up with him. And you know, he just said he was going to verify. I says, "Can you please make sure what the state statute says on this as well?" I says because I find it interesting if one area we can ask for ID and the other area we do not. To me, that tells me that's part of our state statute. So, you know, I just want to be consistent whatever we do.

MR: Sure, sure.

JP: So he's got to still investigate that. But in regards to the employees, now, unfortunately, Layton has a weak mayor form of government. So I cannot hire or fire anybody. Okay. I have to go through the city manager. That's his role. That's his responsibility.

So I did go to him and said, look, I want to know what, you know, what the deal is here. How did, you know, our attorney find out any details about this man? What's going on? And so he did report back to me and he says that all he did was, I guess, in the course of the conversation with you, he picked up on a couple of different names you used and he went online and looked that way. Meaning that he just, you know, did some Facebook type things.

MR: I don't... stalking or whatever it is... yeah I don't... I don't believe that for a second though Mayor. And I don't... you know, and I forgot to send you the phone call and the links that I sent you in that email, um, but his... The way that he answered, it's, I mean, it is undeniable that, I mean, I use the alias name Don Matthews a lot. I mean, using an alias is not illegal, you know.

JP: No, it's not.

MR: And I, but I simply, all I simply told him was that I was, you know, I was a journalist. I didn't work with any of the main stations around here. And I... you know there's how he came across Matthew Reardon whenever I told him Don Matthews. There's there's absolutely no... I mean it doesn't... it's... it doesn't add up and I'll tell you... I what I 100% believe happened here is I... I truly believed that this was Lafayette County, Mississippi that was behind this.

And I say that in full confidence because this is a move right out of their playbook. And I want to, I want to warn you about, about Lafayette County and the types of stuff that they're up to. So they, so they conspired with Galveston, Texas back in 2023. It was two deputies that called over to Galveston. I went down there as a journalist. I had received tips that the Galveston Police Department was racially profiling people and making false arrests. It was multiple reports that I received. And as I was going into the city limits of Galveston, I got pulled over. Come to find out what happened was Lafayette County had, you know, gotten in touch. It was all a staged arrest. Lafayette County's nonsense. They're...

Basically, it's been a ploy to try to silence me, and that's hence the reason why I like to use the alias, because I've been gaslighted, I've been retaliated against, and these people are straight assholes. Evil, and I think that they found, you know, that I was over here in Layton, and I think that... and what I truly believe, and this is based on evidence, my attorney has got a ton of evidence that, you know, recorded phone calls from them. I believe that... They reached out, they spoke to Mark, somebody at Lafayette County spoke to Mark, and then that's how Mark came across my name. I don't believe that he just randomly stumbled upon it. It's a lot more serious than that.

And that's why I'd asked to check in on that because... They cannot do that to people, Mayor. I mean, that's, I have the right to life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness. And you know, these people need to leave me alone down in Mississippi. That is, it is by far the most corrupt state in the country. That's why I wanted to get away from there.

JP: Yeah, I'm playing out with two.

MR: Yeah, it's horrible. I mean, it's absolutely horrible. And, you know, I wanted to change my people, place some things, come out here. And I believe there's no reason that Mark should have gotten all the information that he got from the conversation that we had. I know that's not the case. I know that there was some communication. And I believe that somebody reached out to him. I don't think that he knew about me to reach out and confirm any other. I believe that it was some type of communication that was, you know, initiated into and into the city somehow.

So can I do a public records request into... I know this is... this is going to sound a bit, you know... I'm not trying to get privileged information with the legal department. I know the city attorneys. But what I do want is I need to find out from, I guess it would be February 3rd until the date that this became an issue. I

need to get a phone log to see about any calls that came in that would have been from that area code, or if there's any uh email correspondence um in regards to me that has been sent and received from...

[Brief pause as MR drops pen]

MR: Uh... I just dropped my pen...

JP: Okay... you want records from that... any phone logs from our department is what you're asking?

MR: Uh yes ma'am... I mean I would say that it was uh... I would... I will start with you know that would have gone into the city attorney's office because I mean obviously Mark talked to somebody and so I'm trying to you know if... if uh... if these people in Mississippi are seriously up to the same things I need to definitely get my attorney on that to stop that, you know, and so I need to confirm because, I mean, when...

Are you okay if I just go, you know, I mean, I'll...

JP: I think that we just need to come out and ask him.

MR: Yeah absolutely... I mean that... that rather than go to all this effort... I mean I just need to ask...

JP: Yeah and if he says yes then that gets your answer you need right?

MR: It does.

JP: No then you take it a step further right?

MR: Um... and... and do you think that... do you think that he would be forthcoming with that information though?

JP: I don't know him well enough to say. I wish I could say, oh yeah, I know him well enough. He's pretty honest, dude. I don't know. I don't honestly, I don't interact enough with him to even make that call.

MR: I understand. OK, well, yeah, I wanted to. So that's the reason why it was a big concern to me. And, you know, I wanted to bring you in the loop on that. You know, obviously, I don't... You know, it's uncomfortable talking about the things that those people have done.

I literally... I spent... I mean, it was so bad, Mayor. I spent nearly 11 months in jail on a false DWI accusation. The officer claimed that he smelled alcohol. I hadn't drank in four, five years. Demanded a breathalyzer. They wouldn't give me a breathalyzer. They literally locked me up on suspicion. And they did that so that... Lafayette County could come in. I was on an unsupervised non-reporting probation and Lafayette County did that so that they could come in and revoke my probation and send me to prison based on something that they had conspired to bring about. That was actually vacated at the beginning of the year, declared unlawful, illegal and vacated.

JP: I can't imagine anybody spending that long on just a DUI.

MR: It was that long in the Galveston County Jail because Lafayette County had a no-bond hold on me to try to extradite me back to Lafayette County, Mississippi. So literally, they drug that thing out as long as possible, knowing that I couldn't bond out. And then they extradited me. They robbed me of a trial to where, you know, my innocence could be 100 percent proven. They had the officer over in Galveston actually testify and tell lies over a Zoom meeting at my revocation hearing in Lafayette County saying that there was alcohol in my system when the toxicology report clearly showed that there was not like it's... it's...

This stuff, I mean, it's literally, it's like, it's stuff like out of a John Grisham novel. I'm actually writing a novel right now, actually. I'm about 150 pages into it, working on expanding it out. But it's some of the craziest, craziest stuff. And that's the thing. I think I told you I'm a Marine Corps veteran. I swore a lifelong oath to protect and defend our Constitution. And, you know...

This stuff, I mean, I take it very seriously because, you know, I don't, I'm basically at the end of the day, it's, it's destroyed my life. I feel like it's all destroyed my life and I have to, I have to fight for my kids' generation or else they don't have anything. You know, if this stuff can get ignored and basically, you know, people can turn a blind eye to it and allow it to happen, then what do they have to look forward to?

JP: Yeah, you're right. So... Okay. Well, let me, you know, probably, you know, I'll try to find out late tomorrow afternoon when I go in.

MR: Thank you so much, ma'am.

JP: But I'll ask the question anyway to find out.

MR: Yes, ma'am. Well, I appreciate your help. Thank you so much.

JP: Sure. Yep. All right. Okay. You have a good day.

MR: You too, ma'am. All right. Bye-bye.

End of Transcript